21.5 Food Adulteration

Adulteration is defined as the addition or subtraction of any substance to or from food, so that the natural composition and the quality of food substance is affected. **Adulterant** is any material which is used for the purpose of adulteration.

Some of the commonly adulterated foods are milk and milk products, cereals, pulses, coffee powder, tea powder, turmeric powder, saffron, confectionary, non-alcoholic beverages, spices, edible oils, meat, poultry products etc. The adulterants in food can be classified in three categories:

1. Natural adulterants
2. Incidental/unintentionally added adulterants
3. Intentionally added adulterants

1. Natural adulterants

Natural adulterants are those chemicals or organic compounds that are naturally present in food. e.g. toxic substances in certain poisonous mushrooms, Prussic acid in seeds of apples and cherry, marine toxins, fish oil poisoning, environmental contaminants

2. Incidental/unintentionally added adulterants

These types of adulterants are added unknowingly due to ignorance or carelessness during food handling and packaging. It includes:

a. Pesticide residues

b. Droppings of rodents, insects, rodent bites and larva in food during its storage

c. Microbial contamination due to the presence of pathogens like *Escherichia coli*, *Salmonella* in fruits, vegetables, ready-to-eat meat and poultry products

3. Intentionally added adulterants

These adulterants are added intentionally for financial gain and have serious impact on the health of the consumers. These types of adulterants include:

a. Additives and preservatives like vinegar, citric acid, sodium bicarbonate (baking soda), hydrogen peroxide in milk, modified food starch, food flavours, synthetic preservatives and artificial sweeteners.

b. Chemicals like calcium carbide to ripen bananas and mangoes.

c. Non certified food colours containing chemicals like metallic lead are used to give colours to vegetables like green leafy vegetables, bitter gourd, green peas etc. These colours are added to give a fresh look to the vegetables.



d. Edible synthetic wax like shellac or carnauba wax is coated on fruits like apple, pear to give a shining appearance.

21.5.1 Health Effects of Adulterated Foods

Consumption of these adulterated foods may lead to serious health effects like fever, diarrhoea, nausea, vomiting, gastrointestinal disorders, asthma, allergy, neurological disorder, skin allergies, immune suppression, kidney and liver failure, colon cancer and even birth defects.

21.6 Food Quality Control

The government always ensures that pure and safe food is made available to the consumers. In 1954, the Indian Government enacted the Food Law known as Prevention of Food Adulteration Act and the Prevention of Food Adulteration Rules in 1955 with the objective of ensuring pure and wholesome food to the consumers and protect them from fraudulent trade practices.

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